

COURSE 2A

C2-08 SENIOR BUSINESS ANALYSIS & COMMUNICATION

BEGINNER-FIRST TEACHING BOOK - RC4

Discovery -> challenge -> priority -> evidence -> executive decisions -> defense -> mentoring

THIS BOOK IS YOUR TEACHER

Management judgment is assessed with changed cases and evidence, not a fake software runtime.

This book is your teacher

Use one lesson at a time. New advanced concepts are still taught from first principles. Save a genuine attempt before opening protected review; do not skim ahead just because a topic name looks familiar.

Daily lesson loop

1) Why it matters -> 2) what you learn -> 3) prerequisite -> 4) picture it in your head -> 5) new words -> 6) watch / visual source when useful -> 7) follow with me once -> 8) expected result -> 9) why it worked -> 10) common beginner mistakes -> 11) recovery ladder -> 12) small fresh task -> 13) validate -> 14) teach it back -> 15) protected review + changed retry -> 16) evidence / mastery + exact next route.

Source rule

External videos are companions, not the course authority. If a useful source exists, open the exact link and return to the course task. If an external source would leak a solved capstone or add little value, the lesson explicitly uses an INTERNAL TEACHING ROUTE.

Attempt protection

Do the teacher example once. Then close it and complete the changed task from your own blank workbook/query/report/notebook. Protected review opens only after a saved attempt and is followed by a changed retry.

Mastery standard

You are finished only when you can reproduce the result, validate it, explain why it works, recover from a mistake and save the required evidence.

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Every canonical C2-08 lesson and actual page number

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Prerequisite and tool map

Senior judgment still starts with explicit definitions and evidence

ASSUMED	
Course 1 analysis/report fundamentals and C2-00 to C2-07 concepts as examples. You do not need management experience. Every new stakeholder/decision/review concept is defined before use.	
CORE TOOLS	OPTIONAL VISUALS / AI
Teaching Book + case/evidence workbook + synthetic stakeholder briefs/KPI evidence. Word processor, spreadsheet or notes app may be used for drafts; the supplied workbook keeps assessment evidence consistent.	Selected videos improve stakeholder interviewing/storytelling. Copilot/AI can help draft summaries/questions, but must not invent evidence, choose owners or replace your verification/recommendation judgment.
PL-300 POSITION	
Current PL-300 expects meaningful business value, easy-to-understand visualizations and work with business stakeholders plus analytics/data engineers. C2-08 deepens those professional behaviors; most SBA lessons are broader than direct exam objectives.	

Practice, review and Gate route

Fresh case -> decision evidence -> written defense -> changed retry



LESSON RULE

Use matching P_SBA# workbook sheet after exact lesson pages. Save first response before protected review. Review compares decision/evidence quality—not wording. Close review before changed retry.

MINI-LAB

Management Review Simulation: ambiguous Growth request, cross-functional conflict, partial evidence, uncertainty and executive defense. Deliver discovery brief, priority/recommendation memo and review Q&A.

GATES

A Marketplace Sellers, B Inventory Replenishment, C Customer Success Renewals. Distinct stakeholder conflicts/evidence/decision constraints. B/C protected fresh reassessments.

SBA1 - Running a stakeholder discovery conversation

1. Why it matters

A request such as 'build me a dashboard' is not a requirement. If you start building before discovering the decision, audience, definitions and constraints, you can deliver exactly what was asked and still solve the wrong problem.

2. What you are learning

Prepare and conduct a structured discovery conversation that uncovers business decision, audience, current process, metric definitions, scope, data/freshness, constraints, success criteria, owner and next step.

3. Prerequisite / what you already know

Course 1 business-question thinking and basic report experience. No formal Business Analyst qualification is assumed.

4. Picture it in your head

Mental model

Discovery funnel: start with the decision and audience, then narrow through definitions, constraints, evidence, open questions and acceptance. The requested output is only a proposed format until the decision it supports is clear.

5. New words before we use them

Stakeholder: Person/group affected by or accountable for the decision/solution. Elicitation: Structured process of drawing out needs, rules, constraints and context. Acceptance criterion: Observable condition showing that a requirement/deliverable is acceptable.

6. Watch / visual source

VISUAL/SOURCE ROUTE: Required visual: Passionate Business Analyst stakeholder interview - 0:00 overview, 1:56 three steps, 8:23 pro tips. Microsoft report-r <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TAhivp4Iu-o>

After watching/opening: return to this lesson and reproduce the worked example from your own file/query/report. Save course-task evidence, not a screenshot of the source.

7. Follow with me once

Teacher demonstration - do this once with me, then close the example before your fresh task.

- 1 Ask the decision first: 'What decision should this help you make, and how often?' Avoid beginning with chart types.
- 2 Identify audience/owner: who uses it, who approves definitions, who acts on the result?
- 3 Understand current process and pain: what do they do today, where does it break, what is the cost/risk?
- 4 Clarify metric/filters/grain/freshness and examples. Ask what 'sales', 'active customer' or 'late' specifically mean.
- 5 Close by restating scope, unanswered questions, success/acceptance criteria, owner and next action. Send the summary for confirmation.

8. What you should see / be able to say

Expected result

A one-page discovery brief that another analyst can read without guessing the decision or definitions.

9. Why it worked

Reasoning

The conversation converts a feature request into decision + evidence + constraints + acceptance. Professional upgrade: Strong discovery is concise and iterative. Use examples, playback/confirmation and explicit decision ownership. A workshop or follow-up may be needed when multiple business areas define the same metric differently.

10. Common beginner mistakes

1. Ask only 'what columns/charts do you want?'. | 2. Accept ambiguous KPI names. | 3. Interview only the loudest executive and skip actual users/owners. | 4. Leave meeting without written confirmation or unanswered-question list.

11. If you get stuck - recovery ladder

Recovery

Use six anchors: decision, user, current process, definition, constraint/data, acceptance. If one is blank, ask one focused follow-up. Save the genuine attempt before review.

12. Now you do a small version alone

Fresh independent task

Fresh case: Operations asks for a 'delivery performance dashboard by tomorrow'. Write 12 discovery questions and a confirmed decision brief.

13. Validate your result

Validation

Every question has a purpose; brief includes decision, user, KPI definition owner, scope, freshness, constraint, acceptance and next step.

14. Teach it back in your own words

Explain without reading

Explain why 'What chart do you want?' is usually too early.

15. Protected review + changed fresh retry

Attempt protection

Save your questions/brief first. Changed retry uses a Finance request for 'profit by customer' with an unclear cost-allocation definition.

16. Evidence / mastery + exact next route

Mastery evidence

Discovery agenda + 12 questions + playback summary + open-questions/owners + acceptance criteria + explain-back. After saving evidence, continue to SBA2.

SBA2 - Challenging a bad request professionally

1. Why it matters

Senior analysts are not order takers. A requested metric, chart or deadline can be misleading, impossible or harmful. The job is to protect the decision without turning the conversation into 'analyst versus stakeholder'.

2. What you are learning

Challenge a weak request by acknowledging the goal, identifying the concrete risk, showing evidence/assumption, offering viable options and asking the correct decision owner to choose.

3. Prerequisite / what you already know

SBA1 discovery and ability to explain data/metric limitations simply.

4. Picture it in your head

Mental model

Request-to-decision translation: separate the stakeholder request from the underlying business decision, then expose risk/constraint, explain why the literal request may mislead, propose a safer alternative and name the decision owner.

5. New words before we use them

Pushback: Professional challenge to a request because of risk, feasibility or decision quality. Trade-off: What is gained and sacrificed by choosing one option. Decision owner: Person accountable for choosing among legitimate business trade-offs.

6. Watch / visual source

VISUAL/SOURCE ROUTE: Book-led; Microsoft BI business-alignment guidance reinforces solution-oriented business/technical discussions.

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/power-bi/guidance/fabric-adoption-roadmap-business-alignment>

After watching/opening: return to this lesson and reproduce the worked example from your own file/query/report. Save course-task evidence, not a screenshot of the source.

7. Follow with me once

Teacher demonstration - do this once with me, then close the example before your fresh task.

- 1 Acknowledge goal: leadership wants to identify performance differences.
- 2 State risk without accusation: raw revenue may mostly reflect territory/account mix and can mislabel strong/weak performance.
- 3 Show a small control: revenue per active account and territory potential tell a materially different story for two reps.
- 4 Offer options: raw revenue as one context metric; normalized comparison; or a two-part scorecard with explicit limitations.
- 5 Ask the accountable Sales leader to approve the comparison rule and document the final decision.

8. What you should see / be able to say

Expected result

Pushback that protects analysis quality while preserving stakeholder trust and momentum.

9. Why it worked

Reasoning

You object to the decision risk, not to the person, and provide a path forward. Professional upgrade: Good pushback is early, specific and reversible where possible. Escalate only when risk/ownership demands it; preserve a decision log when material definitions or controls are changed.

10. Common beginner mistakes

1. 'No, that metric is wrong.' | 2. Hide behind technical jargon. | 3. Agree publicly then quietly change the requirement. | 4. Offer five options but never identify who decides.

11. If you get stuck - recovery ladder

Recovery

Use sentence frame: 'I understand the goal is ___. The risk with ___ is ___ because ___. We can do A or B; the trade-off is ___. Who should approve the choice?' Save the genuine attempt before review.

12. Now you do a small version alone

Fresh independent task

Fresh case: Product asks you to remove refunded orders because 'they make conversion look bad'. Write a professional response and two alternatives.

13. Validate your result

Validation

Response names business goal, risk/evidence, options/trade-offs, decision owner and documented outcome.

14. Teach it back in your own words

Explain without reading

Explain the difference between challenging a stakeholder and challenging a decision assumption.

15. Protected review + changed fresh retry

Attempt protection

Attempt first. Changed retry challenges an impossible same-day deadline without saying only 'we need more time'.

16. Evidence / mastery + exact next route

Mastery evidence

Written pushback + alternative options + trade-off/owner + decision log entry + explain-back. After saving evidence, continue to SBA3.

SBA3 - Prioritizing analytical work

1. Why it matters

A senior analyst rarely has one request. If priority is decided by who messages most often, strategic work gets displaced and deadlines become promises nobody can defend.

2. What you are learning

Create a transparent priority system using value/decision impact, urgency/time sensitivity, effort, risk, dependencies and strategic/regulatory commitment; use scoring as evidence, not fake mathematical truth.

3. Prerequisite / what you already know

SBA1 decision framing and basic estimation.

4. Picture it in your head

Mental model

Triage board: compare candidate work by decision impact, urgency, evidence confidence, effort/dependency and non-negotiable risk. Priority is an explicit trade-off, not whoever asks loudest or whatever is easiest to build.

5. New words before we use them

Priority: Relative order in which work should receive scarce time/attention. Dependency: Other decision, data, person or work that must happen first or constrains delivery. WIP: Work in progress; too much simultaneous work increases context switching and delay.

6. Watch / visual source

VISUAL/SOURCE ROUTE: Book-led; Microsoft BI strategic planning provides current prioritization/alignment context.

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/power-bi/guidance/powerbi-implementation-planning-bi-strategy-bi-strategic-planning>

After watching/opening: return to this lesson and reproduce the worked example from your own file/query/report. Save course-task evidence, not a screenshot of the source.

7. Follow with me once

Teacher demonstration - do this once with me, then close the example before your fresh task.

- 1 For each request write decision/consumer and consequence of delay. 'CEO asked' is context, not sufficient benefit description.
- 2 Separate hard deadlines (regulatory/contractual) from preference-based urgency.
- 3 Estimate effort/risk with rough bands rather than pretending precision you do not have.
- 4 Mark dependencies and work already committed. A high-value request blocked on unavailable data may not be executable now.
- 5 Publish proposed order and the consequence: 'If urgent request X enters this week, Y moves to next week.' Get the accountable manager to confirm trade-offs.

8. What you should see / be able to say

Expected result

A priority board that makes both chosen work and displaced work visible.

9. Why it worked

Reasoning

Priority becomes a transparent management decision rather than a private analyst guess. Professional upgrade: Teams can use RICE, WSJF, impact/effort or custom frameworks, but senior analysts must expose assumptions, dependencies and decision authority rather than hiding judgment behind decimals.

10. Common beginner mistakes

1. Complex weighted score presented as objective truth. | 2. Urgency equals importance. | 3. Start all high-priority items at once. | 4. Accept new work without showing what moves.

11. If you get stuck - recovery ladder

Recovery

Use five columns: decision/value, deadline, effort/risk, dependency, displacement. Rank only after these are visible. Save the genuine attempt before review.

12. Now you do a small version alone

Fresh independent task

Fresh case: prioritize eight BI requests including a regulatory fix, executive experiment, recurring manual report, broken dashboard and low-value formatting request.

13. Validate your result

Validation

Top order has defensible reasons; blocked/deferred work is explicit; one incoming urgent request shows displacement.

14. Teach it back in your own words

Explain without reading

Explain why a priority score is a conversation aid rather than a scientific measurement.

15. Protected review + changed fresh retry

Attempt protection

Attempt first. Changed retry adds a production incident halfway through the week and requires reprioritization.

16. Evidence / mastery + exact next route

Mastery evidence

Priority matrix + assumptions + dependency/WIP notes + displaced-work communication + explain-back. After saving evidence, continue to SBA4.

SBA4 - Separating observation, inference and recommendation

1. Why it matters

A chart can prove that two values moved together; it usually cannot prove why. Mixing observation, interpretation and advice makes analyses sound more certain than the evidence supports.

2. What you are learning

Label observations, interpretations/hypotheses and recommendations separately; test alternative explanations; avoid causal claims that data/design cannot support.

3. Prerequisite / what you already know

Basic descriptive analytics and validation.

4. Picture it in your head

Mental model

Evidence ladder: Observation = directly supported by data; Inference = plausible interpretation with alternatives/assumptions; Recommendation = action proposed for a decision. Never let a recommendation masquerade as observed fact.

5. New words before we use them

Observation: Statement directly supported by measured data under stated definitions. Inference: Interpretation/hypothesis drawn from observations and assumptions. Recommendation: Proposed action based on evidence, objectives and trade-offs. Causality: Claim that changing one factor causes another outcome, requiring stronger evidence than correlation alone.

6. Watch / visual source

VISUAL/SOURCE ROUTE: Recommended storytelling visual later in SBA5; this lesson is evidence-language led.

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/credentials/certifications/resources/study-guides/pl-300>

After watching/opening: return to this lesson and reproduce the worked example from your own file/query/report. Save course-task evidence, not a screenshot of the source.

7. Follow with me once

Teacher demonstration - do this once with me, then close the example before your fresh task.

- 1 Observation: conversion fell from 4.8% to 4.1% after 15 June under the same metric definition.
- 2 Do not jump to 'price increase caused the decline'. List possible causes: traffic mix, campaign shift, outage, seasonality, competitor action, measurement change.
- 3 Check available controls/segments/timing and record which explanations are supported, contradicted or still unknown.
- 4 Inference: the timing and segment pattern make pricing a plausible contributor, but the current observational data does not isolate its causal effect.
- 5 Recommendation: run a controlled pricing test or inspect the strongest competing explanation first, with owner/success criterion.

8. What you should see / be able to say

Expected result

A decision note where facts, interpretations and actions can be challenged independently.

9. Why it worked

Reasoning

Uncertainty in explanation does not prevent action; it changes the action and the language. Professional upgrade: Executives need confidence calibrated to evidence. Use causal language only when design/evidence supports it; otherwise use 'associated with', 'consistent with', 'likely contributor' and explicit next tests.

10. Common beginner mistakes

1. Trend = cause. | 2. Use 'proves' when analysis is observational. | 3. List uncertainty so vaguely that no action is possible. | 4. Recommendation presented as another observed fact.

11. If you get stuck - recovery ladder

Recovery

Color/tag every sentence O, I or R. If an inference has no alternative explanation considered, add at least two. Save the genuine attempt before review.

12. Now you do a small version alone

Fresh independent task

Fresh case: churn rose after a support-policy change. Write 4 observations, 3 competing inferences, 2 tests and one cautious recommendation.

13. Validate your result

Validation

Observations are measurable; inferences cite evidence/assumptions; recommendation matches uncertainty and decision urgency.

14. Teach it back in your own words

Explain without reading

Explain why 'A happened before B' is not enough to say A caused B.

15. Protected review + changed fresh retry

Attempt protection

Attempt first. Changed retry analyzes delivery delay and customer complaints with a hidden holiday-season confounder.

16. Evidence / mastery + exact next route

Mastery evidence

O/I/R tagged memo + alternative hypotheses + test/recommendation + explain-back. After saving evidence, continue to SBA5.

SBA5 - Executive summaries

1. Why it matters

2. What you are learning

Write a concise decision-first executive summary with headline, evidence, implication, recommendation, uncertainty/limitation and explicit ask/next step.

3. Prerequisite / what you already know

SBA4 observation/inference/recommendation and C2-04 storytelling.

4. Picture it in your head

Mental model

Inverted pyramid: lead with the decision-relevant headline, then the minimum evidence, implication, uncertainty/trade-off and decision ask. Executives should understand what needs deciding before they reach implementation detail.

5. New words before we use them

Executive summary: Concise decision-oriented synthesis of situation, evidence, implications and next actions. So what: Business consequence/meaning of a finding. Ask: Specific approval, decision, resource or action requested from the audience.

6. Watch / visual source

VISUAL/SOURCE ROUTE: Recommended: storytelling with data 10th anniversary session (2025) for audience/story emphasis; current Power BI design-effective-repo

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=99zIHv1fNdw>

After watching/opening: return to this lesson and reproduce the worked example from your own file/query/report. Save course-task evidence, not a screenshot of the source.

7. Follow with me once

Teacher demonstration - do this once with me, then close the example before your fresh task.

- 1 Decision/headline: 'Renewal risk is concentrated in two enterprise segments; approve targeted retention test this month.'
- 2 Evidence: state 2-3 numbers with period/definition context, not a table dump.
- 3 Implication: quantify or clearly describe business consequence if no action is taken.
- 4 Recommendation: one primary action plus owner/timing.
- 5 Uncertainty/limitation: identify the material caveat only. End with the explicit ask/next decision.

8. What you should see / be able to say

Expected result

A summary readable in under a minute that preserves evidence, uncertainty and action.

9. Why it worked

Reasoning

The summary follows the audience's decision path rather than the analyst's analysis chronology. Professional upgrade: Use layered communication: headline and ask first; supporting visuals/definitions behind it. AI-generated narratives may accelerate drafting, but you remain responsible for factual accuracy, scope and recommendation.

10. Common beginner mistakes

1. Start with 'I analyzed 12 tables...' | 2. Paste every KPI. | 3. Recommendation hidden in last paragraph. | 4. No limitation, or a paragraph of caveats that overwhelms the action.

11. If you get stuck - recovery ladder

Recovery

Use six lines: decision/headline; evidence 1; evidence 2; implication; recommendation; ask + material caveat. Save the genuine attempt before review.

12. Now you do a small version alone

Fresh independent task

Fresh case: write a 120-word executive summary from a regional service-performance snapshot with one data limitation.

13. Validate your result

Validation

Reviewer can answer 'what happened / why care / what do / what decide / what caveat?' without opening supporting pages.

14. Teach it back in your own words

Explain without reading

Explain why an executive summary is not a shorter version of your methodology section.

15. Protected review + changed fresh retry

Attempt protection

Attempt first. Changed retry reduces your summary to 80 words for a CFO while preserving decision and caveat.

16. Evidence / mastery + exact next route

Mastery evidence

120-word summary + 80-word transfer + supporting evidence references + explain-back. After saving evidence, continue to SBA6.

SBA6 - Presenting uncertainty

1. Why it matters

Hiding uncertainty creates false confidence; flooding stakeholders with every caveat makes analysis unusable. Senior communication shows how uncertainty could change the decision.

2. What you are learning

Present uncertainty through known/unknown, data quality/freshness, range/scenario or confidence language; connect uncertainty to decision sensitivity and next evidence.

3. Prerequisite / what you already know

SBA4 evidence-language discipline and basic percentage/range understanding.

4. Picture it in your head

Mental model

Fog map: mark what is known, unknown, assumed and estimated; show a plausible range or scenarios when possible; state which uncertainty could change the decision and when/how evidence will be updated.

5. New words before we use them

Uncertainty: What is not known precisely about a measurement, estimate, explanation or future outcome. Scenario range: Set of plausible outcomes under explicit assumptions. Decision sensitivity: Whether reasonable uncertainty could change which action is preferred.

6. Watch / visual source

VISUAL/SOURCE ROUTE: Book-led. Current Microsoft BI strategy/business-alignment guidance supports transparent communication; statistical method belongs to t

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/power-bi/guidance/fabric-adoption-roadmap-business-alignment>

After watching/opening: return to this lesson and reproduce the worked example from your own file/query/report. Save course-task evidence, not a screenshot of the source.

7. Follow with me once

Teacher demonstration - do this once with me, then close the example before your fresh task.

- 1 Best current estimate: 180 analyst hours saved/month based on 12 sampled workflows.
- 2 Known limitations: sample is concentrated in two teams; manual-time estimates are self-reported.
- 3 Scenario range: conservative 120, base 180, optimistic 230 hours using explicit adoption/volume assumptions.
- 4 Decision sensitivity: project still clears the approval threshold at 120 hours, so uncertainty does not change go/no-go-but affects staffing/benefit commitment.
- 5 Update plan: measure actual time for four weeks after launch and replace estimate with observed range.

8. What you should see / be able to say

Expected result

Uncertainty is visible, proportionate and tied to how the decision could change.

9. Why it worked

Reasoning

You do not pretend precision, but you still give the decision owner a usable recommendation. Professional upgrade: Use statistical intervals when the method supports them and the audience can use them; otherwise transparent scenarios/ranges may communicate decision risk more honestly than decorative precision.

10. Common beginner mistakes

1. Give one decimal-point forecast as fact. | 2. Say 'data may be imperfect' without impact. | 3. Use confidence interval jargon you cannot explain. | 4. List caveats but no plan to reduce uncertainty.

11. If you get stuck - recovery ladder

Recovery

Write: estimate; biggest uncertainty; plausible range/scenarios; does it change decision?; what evidence will update it? Save the genuine attempt before review.

12. Now you do a small version alone

Fresh independent task

Fresh case: estimate churn reduction from a proposed retention campaign using three scenarios and a decision threshold.

13. Validate your result

Validation

Assumptions are explicit; range is internally coherent; language does not imply stronger evidence than available; update plan has owner/timing.

14. Teach it back in your own words

Explain without reading

Explain the difference between being uncertain and being unable to recommend.

15. Protected review + changed fresh retry

Attempt protection

Attempt first. Changed retry introduces stale/incomplete data and asks whether the recommendation still holds.

16. Evidence / mastery + exact next route

Mastery evidence

Uncertainty table + scenario/threshold note + update plan + explain-back. After saving evidence, continue to SBA7.

SBA7 - Recommendations tied to business decisions

1. Why it matters

A recommendation like 'monitor this KPI' often avoids making a decision. Strong recommendations specify an action, owner, timing, trade-off and what evidence will determine whether to continue, change or stop.

2. What you are learning

Turn findings into decision-ready recommendations with action, owner, timing, expected impact, risk/trade-off, success measure and review/stop condition.

3. Prerequisite / what you already know

SBA4-SBA6.

4. Picture it in your head

Mental model

Action contract: a recommendation is not complete until it has action, accountable owner, timing, expected direction of impact, risk/trade-off, success measure and review/stop condition. Monitoring without a decision rule is not an action plan.

5. New words before we use them

Decision rule: Pre-agreed criterion that determines what action to take when evidence reaches a threshold. Reversible action: Action that can be tested/undone with limited cost, making experimentation safer. Success measure: Metric/control used to judge whether the recommendation achieved the intended result.

6. Watch / visual source

VISUAL/SOURCE ROUTE: Book-led; storytelling video supports action-oriented communication.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=99zIHv1fNdw>

After watching/opening: return to this lesson and reproduce the worked example from your own file/query/report. Save course-task evidence, not a screenshot of the source.

7. Follow with me once

Teacher demonstration - do this once with me, then close the example before your fresh task.

- 1 Finding: South enterprise churn is 3.1 points above comparable regions, concentrated in onboarding months 1-2.
- 2 Decision: whether to allocate two customer-success specialists for a six-week onboarding intervention.
- 3 Recommendation: run intervention for new South enterprise accounts; owner Head of CS; launch 1 Oct; cap resource at two FTE-equivalents.
- 4 Expected impact/trade-off: target ≥ 1.5 -point reduction; cost is diverted CS capacity; guardrail complaints/SLA must not worsen.
- 5 Review after six weeks. Continue/scale only if churn proxy/leading measures and guardrails meet the agreed rule; otherwise stop/adjust.

8. What you should see / be able to say

Expected result

A recommendation the decision owner can approve, reject or modify without asking 'what exactly should we do?'

9. Why it worked

Reasoning

Action is bounded and measurable, with explicit trade-offs and review. Professional upgrade: Prefer small reversible experiments when uncertainty is material and delay is tolerable. Use stronger commitments when evidence, regulation or operational urgency justifies them.

10. Common beginner mistakes

1. 'We recommend monitoring.' | 2. No owner/deadline. | 3. Impact claim exceeds evidence. | 4. Success KPI has no baseline/threshold.

11. If you get stuck - recovery ladder

Recovery

Use template: We recommend [action] by [owner] by [time] because [evidence]. Expect [impact]. Risk/trade-off [x]. Measure [y], guardrail [z], review/stop rule [date/threshold]. Save the genuine attempt before review.

12. Now you do a small version alone

Fresh independent task

Fresh case: high delivery cancellations in two cities. Write one reversible recommendation and one larger strategic option.

13. Validate your result

Validation

Each option has owner, timing, impact hypothesis, cost/risk, success/guardrail and decision/review rule.

14. Teach it back in your own words

Explain without reading

Explain why a recommendation should be falsifiable/testable rather than just sound sensible.

15. Protected review + changed fresh retry

Attempt protection

Attempt first. Changed retry has a lower budget and requires changing the action without changing the business goal.

16. Evidence / mastery + exact next route

Mastery evidence

Decision brief + two recommendation options + success/guardrail/review rules + explain-back. After saving evidence, continue to SBA8.

SBA8 - Handling contradictory stakeholder requirements

1. Why it matters

When Finance says 'official revenue must match ledger' and Sales says 'show live booked revenue', both can be reasonable because they support different decisions. Combining them into one unlabeled number creates mistrust.

2. What you are learning

Identify the underlying goals/non-negotiables behind conflicting requests; distinguish definition, scope, timing and policy conflicts; propose options and route the unresolved trade-off to the correct owner.

3. Prerequisite / what you already know

SBA1 discovery, SBA2 pushback and SBA3 priority decisions.

4. Picture it in your head

Mental model

Conflict table: list each stakeholder goal, the non-negotiable constraint, the actual point of conflict, viable options and the person authorized to choose the trade-off. The analyst surfaces conflict; they do not silently invent a compromise.

5. New words before we use them

Non-negotiable: Constraint that cannot be traded away by the analyst, such as regulatory/accounting/security rule. Conflict log: Record of incompatible requirements, options, owners and final decision. Source of truth: Authoritative data/definition for a specific governed purpose-not necessarily one universal table for every decision.

6. Watch / visual source

VISUAL/SOURCE ROUTE: Microsoft business-alignment guidance is recommended; lesson remains case-led.

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/power-bi/guidance/fabric-adoption-roadmap-business-alignment>

After watching/opening: return to this lesson and reproduce the worked example from your own file/query/report. Save course-task evidence, not a screenshot of the source.

7. Follow with me once

Teacher demonstration - do this once with me, then close the example before your fresh task.

- 1 Write each stakeholder's actual decision: Finance closes accounts; Sales monitors pipeline/bookings daily.
- 2 Identify definition/timing conflict: recognized ledger revenue vs booked commercial value. Do not force them into one unlabeled metric.
- 3 Mark non-negotiables: Finance close must reconcile to ledger; Sales can use operational leading measure if clearly labeled.
- 4 Offer design: two explicitly named metrics/views with definitions and reconciliation bridge, or one executive page with separate official/operational sections.
- 5 Assign metric-definition owner and document final choice, audience and warning against cross-purpose comparison.

8. What you should see / be able to say

Expected result

Conflict is resolved or escalated as a business decision; the analyst does not silently choose a winner.

9. Why it worked

Reasoning

Both requirements are translated to their legitimate decision contexts. Professional upgrade: Enterprise BI often needs governed metric namespaces/purpose labels and a decision log. Consensus is useful; forced semantic compromise can be dangerous.

10. Common beginner mistakes

1. Average/merge two definitions to make everyone 'happy'. | 2. Let hierarchy alone determine truth when policy says otherwise. | 3. Create two metrics with same label. | 4. Keep disagreement verbal and forget after release.

11. If you get stuck - recovery ladder

Recovery

Create conflict table: stakeholder, decision, requirement, why needed, non-negotiable?, conflict type, options, trade-off, decision owner. Save the genuine attempt before review.

12. Now you do a small version alone

Fresh independent task

Fresh case: Product wants weekly active users by event activity; Finance wants billable active accounts. Resolve without creating one misleading 'active' metric.

13. Validate your result

Validation

Every conflicting definition has decision purpose and owner; chosen labels prevent accidental substitution; unresolved trade-off goes to accountable owner.

14. Teach it back in your own words

Explain without reading

Explain why two different 'correct' metrics can coexist if they answer different decisions.

15. Protected review + changed fresh retry

Attempt protection

Attempt first. Changed retry introduces Privacy's data-minimization constraint against Marketing's detailed segmentation request.

16. Evidence / mastery + exact next route

Mastery evidence

Conflict log + option/trade-off matrix + final definition/owner + explain-back. After saving evidence, continue to SBA9.

SBA9 - Defending your analysis under questioning

1. Why it matters

A senior review is not a test of confidence. Good analysts can defend evidence, state assumptions, admit what they do not know and update a conclusion when a valid challenge changes the facts.

2. What you are learning

Prepare a defense map; answer questions with claim/evidence/limitation; distinguish challenge from new requirement; handle 'I don't know' professionally; revise conclusions when evidence warrants.

3. Prerequisite / what you already know

SBA4-SBA7.

4. Picture it in your head

Mental model

Defense map: link every important claim to evidence, assumption/limitation, likely challenge and revision trigger. A strong defense can say "I do not know yet" and specify what evidence would change the answer.

5. New words before we use them

Defense map: Preparation linking each key claim/recommendation to evidence, assumptions, likely challenges and fallback detail. Assumption: Condition treated as true for the analysis/recommendation but not fully established by direct evidence. Revision trigger: New evidence that would materially change the conclusion/recommendation.

6. Watch / visual source

VISUAL/SOURCE ROUTE: Storytelling with data is optional visual support for audience-focused presentation; practice is primarily live/role-play writing.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=99zIHv1fNdw>

After watching/opening: return to this lesson and reproduce the worked example from your own file/query/report. Save course-task evidence, not a screenshot of the source.

7. Follow with me once

Teacher demonstration - do this once with me, then close the example before your fresh task.

- 1 List your three strongest claims and the exact evidence/definitions supporting each.
- 2 For each, write the strongest plausible challenge: data completeness, comparison group, seasonality, cost or unintended consequence.
- 3 Prepare concise answer: direct answer first, evidence second, limitation third. Do not drown the room in methodology unless asked.
- 4 If you do not know, say what is unknown, whether it affects the decision and when/how you will verify it.
- 5 If a valid challenge breaks an assumption, update the recommendation. Defending analysis does not mean defending every original sentence.

8. What you should see / be able to say

Expected result

A calm, evidence-linked review where uncertainty and revision improve trust rather than appearing as weakness.

9. Why it worked

Reasoning

The objective is decision quality, not winning an argument. Professional upgrade: Use an appendix/evidence pack for detail while keeping verbal answers decision-focused. Record unanswered questions and commitments after the meeting.

10. Common beginner mistakes

1. Answer every question with more charts. | 2. Bluff when you do not know. | 3. Treat criticism as personal disagreement. | 4. Never change recommendation after new evidence.

11. If you get stuck - recovery ladder

Recovery

Prepare one card per claim: claim; evidence; definition; assumption; likely challenge; concise answer; revision trigger. Save the genuine attempt before review.

12. Now you do a small version alone

Fresh independent task

Fresh case: defend a recommendation to close a low-volume service location against Finance, Operations and Sales questions.

13. Validate your result

Validation

Answers address the question directly, cite evidence/assumption, acknowledge real limitations and define what would change the recommendation.

14. Teach it back in your own words

Explain without reading

Explain why changing your conclusion after better evidence is a strength, not a failed defense.

15. Protected review + changed fresh retry

Attempt protection

Attempt first. Changed retry adds one valid data-quality challenge that requires narrowing-not abandoning-the recommendation.

16. Evidence / mastery + exact next route

Mastery evidence

Defense map + 8-question Q&A + revision trigger + follow-up log + explain-back. After saving evidence, continue to SBA10.

SBA10 - Working with engineers, finance, product and operations

1. Why it matters

Cross-functional teams fail when everyone assumes another team owns definitions, data, deployment or acceptance. Senior analysts translate business decisions into evidence and contracts that each discipline can act on.

2. What you are learning

Recognize each partner's common concerns; assign accountable ownership with RACI-like clarity; create handoffs for data, metric and operational changes; define acceptance together.

3. Prerequisite / what you already know

SBA1, SBA8 and C2-07 collaboration/handoff concepts.

4. Picture it in your head

Mental model

Handshake contracts: Finance, Product, Operations and Engineering each need explicit inputs, outputs, definitions, owners, deadlines, failure/escalation rules and acceptance evidence. Cross-functional trust comes from visible contracts, not informal memory.

5. New words before we use them

RACI: Responsibility aid: Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, Informed. Acceptance test: Concrete evidence showing the delivered change satisfies the agreed business/technical requirement. Interface contract: Agreement at a team boundary: data/definition/input/output/owner/failure expectations.

6. Watch / visual source

VISUAL/SOURCE ROUTE: Microsoft BI business-alignment guidance is recommended; current PL-300 profile also explicitly expects analyst collaboration with busi

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/power-bi/guidance/fabric-adoption-roadmap-business-alignment>

After watching/opening: return to this lesson and reproduce the worked example from your own file/query/report. Save course-task evidence, not a screenshot of the source.

7. Follow with me once

Teacher demonstration - do this once with me, then close the example before your fresh task.

- 1 Finance owns/accountably approves margin definition/accounting treatment; analyst translates it into testable calculation examples.
- 2 Data/analytics engineer owns required curated fields/pipeline/model transformations; handoff includes source/grain/key/freshness/sample expected results.
- 3 Product/Operations explain the decision/workflow and adoption constraints; analyst ensures report/action fits how work is done.
- 4 Analyst owns analysis/report interpretation, validation and communication unless organizational roles assign differently.
- 5 Create acceptance pack: Finance reconciliation examples, engineering data-quality checks, user decision scenario and owner sign-off.

8. What you should see / be able to say

Expected result

A cross-functional plan with no invisible ownership gap between business definition, data production and decision use.

9. Why it worked

Reasoning

Each role receives the context/evidence it needs while one accountable owner remains clear for each decision. Professional upgrade: RACI is useful only when it clarifies action. Keep it small and pair it with concrete interface/acceptance contracts.

10. Common beginner mistakes

1. RACI with everyone accountable. | 2. Analyst owns accounting definition without Finance approval. | 3. Engineer receives vague 'need customer data'. | 4. Operations informed only after report launch.

11. If you get stuck - recovery ladder

Recovery

12. Now you do a small version alone

Fresh independent task

Fresh case: create a cancellation-risk dashboard requiring Product event definitions, Engineering pipeline fields, Finance cost and Operations intervention.

13. Validate your result

Validation

Every important deliverable has one accountable owner; handoffs have grain/definition/evidence; acceptance spans technical + business use.

14. Teach it back in your own words

Explain without reading

Explain why ownership is about decisions/deliverables, not job-title hierarchy.

15. Protected review + changed fresh retry

Attempt protection

Attempt first. Changed retry removes one source field and requires renegotiating the cross-team acceptance scope.

16. Evidence / mastery + exact next route

Mastery evidence

RACI + data/metric contract + acceptance matrix + explain-back. After saving evidence, continue to SBA11.

SBA11 - Code, review and documentation habits

1. Why it matters

Senior analyst work must survive handover and review. A correct SQL query hidden in 'final_final_v3.sql' with no definition or validation is fragile even if the numbers are right today.

2. What you are learning

Create lightweight professional documentation around SQL/Power Query/Python/BI changes: purpose, input/output grain, assumptions, validation, version/change log, review comments and reproducible evidence.

3. Prerequisite / what you already know

Technical modules C2-01 to C2-07; no Git expertise beyond basic repository habits is assumed.

4. Picture it in your head

Mental model

Change trail: work item -> versioned change/diff -> peer review -> validation -> documentation/change log -> release. Reproducibility means another person can understand the purpose, inputs, assumptions and checks without tribal knowledge.

5. New words before we use them

Peer review: Another person checks correctness, clarity, risk and evidence before release. Change log: Record of meaningful changes, reason, date/owner and possible impact. Reproducibility: Ability for another person/process to recreate the intended result from documented code/config/data assumptions.

6. Watch / visual source

VISUAL/SOURCE ROUTE: Book-led; GitHub review tooling is optional implementation detail, not required for the competency.

<https://docs.github.com/en/pull-requests/collaborating-with-pull-requests/reviewing-changes-in-pull-requests>

After watching/opening: return to this lesson and reproduce the worked example from your own file/query/report. Save course-task evidence, not a screenshot of the source.

7. Follow with me once

Teacher demonstration - do this once with me, then close the example before your fresh task.

- 1 README/work-item states business question, source tables, output grain, KPI definitions/assumptions and owner.
- 2 Query is readable and avoids unexplained magic constants; comments explain business reasoning or non-obvious choices.
- 3 Reviewer checks grain/joins/filters/nulls/date boundaries and compares to an independent control or prior approved result.
- 4 Review comment is specific: issue, why it matters, suggested direction or question. Author responds/repairs and saves evidence.
- 5 Change log records what changed and downstream impact; released artifact can be traced to the reviewed version.

8. What you should see / be able to say

Expected result

A small review package another analyst can understand, rerun and challenge.

9. Why it worked

Reasoning

Correctness evidence and reasoning travel with the code rather than living only in the author's memory. Professional upgrade: Use repository pull requests/change requests when available, but the core habit is traceable peer review plus reproducible evidence. Protect sensitive data in examples/screenshots.

10. Common beginner mistakes

1. Comment every obvious SELECT line but not the business rule. | 2. Reviewer says only 'looks good'. | 3. Rename files instead of version/change control. | 4. Copy sensitive production data into review evidence.

11. If you get stuck - recovery ladder

Recovery

Document five things: purpose, grain, assumptions, validation, change. Then ask reviewer one specific high-risk question. Save the genuine attempt before review.

12. Now you do a small version alone

Fresh independent task

Fresh case: review a junior SQL query that joins monthly targets to order lines and overstates target. Write review comments, corrected design direction and regression checks.

13. Validate your result

Validation

Review catches grain issue, explains impact without humiliating author, asks for evidence and updates documentation/change log.

14. Teach it back in your own words

Explain without reading

Explain why review is not merely checking syntax or formatting.

15. Protected review + changed fresh retry

Attempt protection

Attempt first. Changed retry reviews a pandas transformation with silent coercion and missing exception count.

16. Evidence / mastery + exact next route

Mastery evidence

README/work-item + review comments + validation checklist + change log + explain-back. After saving evidence, continue to SBA12.

SBA12 - Mentoring and reviewing junior analyst work

1. Why it matters

A senior analyst who fixes every junior's work personally becomes a bottleneck. Good mentoring protects business quality while helping the learner understand and repair the reasoning themselves.

2. What you are learning

Review junior work in layers (business question, data/grain, logic, validation, communication); distinguish critical corrections from coaching; ask guiding questions; require changed retry and teach-back; escalate safely when release risk is urgent.

3. Prerequisite / what you already know

All SBA lessons plus technical quality concepts from the course.

4. Picture it in your head

Mental model

Coach loop: ask intent, inspect evidence, point to the reasoning gap, give the smallest useful hint, let the learner repair, require teach-back and recheck on changed evidence. Fixing the work for them protects today but creates tomorrow's bottleneck.

5. New words before we use them

Coaching question: Question designed to help the learner discover/reason through an issue rather than handing over a finished answer. Critical defect: Error/risk that makes the current output unsafe to release or materially misleading. Teach-back: Learner explains the concept/fix in their own words as evidence of understanding.

6. Watch / visual source

VISUAL/SOURCE ROUTE: Book-led; Microsoft data-culture/business-alignment guidance supports mentoring/enabling user communities.

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/power-bi/guidance/fabric-adoption-roadmap-data-culture>

After watching/opening: return to this lesson and reproduce the worked example from your own file/query/report. Save course-task evidence, not a screenshot of the source.

7. Follow with me once

Teacher demonstration - do this once with me, then close the example before your fresh task.

- 1 Start with intent: ask the learner what one row means, what the KPI means and how they validated it.
- 2 Identify critical defect: many-to-many/fan-out join doubles revenue. Block release clearly and explain business impact.
- 3 Do not immediately rewrite query. Ask targeted questions: 'How many order rows before/after join? Is CustomerID unique on the right? What should the relationship/cardinality be?'
- 4 Learner repairs and proves row/total controls. Then ask for changed retry on a different master with a duplicate key.
- 5 Close with teach-back and one development note. If deadline/production risk is urgent, senior may take temporary control while still documenting and returning the learning.

8. What you should see / be able to say

Expected result

Business risk is contained, while the junior-not the senior-does the core reasoning/repair whenever safe.

9. Why it worked

Reasoning

Review separates release safety from skill development and uses evidence rather than authority. Professional upgrade: Senior review should create stronger future independence. Track recurring skill gaps, provide targeted examples and calibrate review depth to risk/experience.

10. Common beginner mistakes

1. Rewrite everything yourself. | 2. Say 'wrong' without showing risk/next question. | 3. Give praise only on style while critical logic is wrong. | 4. Let coaching delay an urgent production containment action.

11. If you get stuck - recovery ladder

Recovery

Use review ladder: goal -> grain -> logic -> validation -> communication. Mark BLOCK vs COACH. Ask one question at a time. Save the genuine attempt before review.

12. Now you do a small version alone

Fresh independent task

Fresh case: junior report has correct total but misleading percent denominator and no limitation note. Write review, coaching questions, changed retry and teach-back prompt.

13. Validate your result

Validation

Critical risk disposition is explicit; feedback is specific/respectful; learner has a path to discover/fix; retry is genuinely changed.

14. Teach it back in your own words

Explain without reading

Explain the difference between mentoring someone and becoming their permanent error-correction engine.

15. Protected review + changed fresh retry

Attempt protection

Attempt first. Changed retry is a junior Python report with swallowed errors and a polished but untrustworthy output.

16. Evidence / mastery + exact next route

Mastery evidence

Layered review + BLOCK/COACH labels + coaching questions + changed retry + teach-back + development note. After saving evidence, complete the module mastery checklist and follow the Gate A / completion route.

C2-08 mastery checklist + quick reference

Use after first pass; judgment is proved by changed cases, not memorized scripts

TWELVE QUESTIONS

SBA1 What decision/user/definition/acceptance is hidden behind the request? | SBA2 Can you challenge the risk while offering a path forward? | SBA3 What gets displaced by this priority? | SBA4 Which sentence is observation, inference or recommendation? | SBA5 Can an executive understand decision/ask in <1 minute? | SBA6 Could uncertainty change the decision? | SBA7 Who does what by when, and how do we know it worked? | SBA8 What underlying goals/non-negotiables cause the conflict? | SBA9 Which evidence/assumption supports each claim and what would revise it? | SBA10 Who owns definition/data/build/use/acceptance? | SBA11 Can another analyst reproduce/review the work? | SBA12 Did the junior reason/repair, or did the senior take over?

BLOCK MASTERY IF

Dashboard request accepted without decision; bad metric accepted silently; priority hides displacement; causal overclaim; executive memo has no action/ask; uncertainty hidden or vague; recommendation has no owner/measure; conflict silently resolved by analyst; bluff under questioning; ownership gaps; unreviewable work; mentoring becomes answer-giving.

FAST COMMUNICATION DEBUG

Decision -> audience/owner -> evidence/definition -> observation vs inference -> alternatives/uncertainty -> recommendation/trade-off -> acceptance/next action. For review/mentoring add: risk -> question -> learner repair -> changed proof.

OPTIONAL PATH

C2-08 is optional Senior/BI professional depth. It strengthens interviews, leadership reviews and promotion readiness but is not a technical prerequisite for the direct Course 1 -> C2B -> C3 path.

C2-08 source / video registry

Internal cases control assessment; selected external material strengthens visual understanding

SBA1 - Passionate Business Analyst - Stakeholder Interview

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TAhivp4lu-o>

0:00 interview; 1:56 three steps; 8:23 pro tips

SBA1,5 - Microsoft Learn - Scope report design requirements

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/training/modules/power-bi-effective-requirements/>

29 min; audience/business goals/report UX

SBA1-3,8,10,12 - Fabric adoption roadmap - Business alignment

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/power-bi/guidance/fabric-adoption-roadmap-business-alignment>

Cross-functional communication, requirements, feedback, priorities

SBA1,3,5 - Power BI implementation planning - BI strategic planning

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/power-bi/guidance/powerbi-implementation-planning-bi-strategy-bi-strategic-planning>

Stakeholders, information gathering, prioritized needs, executive summary

SBA5,7,9 - storytelling with data - decade of data storytelling

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=99zIHv1fNdw>

2025 session; no reliable chapter timestamps retrieved

SBA5 - Microsoft Learn - Design effective reports in Power BI

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/training/paths/power-bi-effective/>

5h07 path; storytelling/decision design; use only relevant modules

SBA5 - Power BI Smart Narrative

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/power-bi/visuals/power-bi-visualization-smart-narrative>

Optional AI/narrative support; analyst must verify output

SBA5 - Copilot explore data / executive summary tutorial

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/power-bi/create-reports/tutorial-copilot-power-bi-explore-data>

Optional drafting example; last updated 2026-05-28

SBA5 - Copilot narrative prompts

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/power-bi/create-reports/copilot-prompts-narratives>

Optional; current 2026 limitations apply

SBA4,10 - PL-300 Study Guide

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/credentials/certifications/resources/study-guides/pl-300>

Current audience: business value + stakeholders + engineers

SBA11 - GitHub - Reviewing changes in pull requests

<https://docs.github.com/en/pull-requests/collaborating-with-pull-requests/reviewing-changes-in-pull-requests>

Optional review-tool implementation

SBA12 - Fabric adoption roadmap - Data culture

<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/power-bi/guidance/fabric-adoption-roadmap-data-culture>

Mentoring, enablement, common analytical vocabulary

VERIFY / FALLBACK

Rechecked 2026-09-10. No external video/source contains an assessment answer; every SBA competency is teachable from this book and the synthetic cases. AI-generated narrative must be verified like any other draft.